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# BELLA THE DIPLOMAT (OR FABRICATOR ?)

Growing up, I considered my mother to be above reproach. She was a nurturer, playful, beautiful, high-spirited and above all, truthful. Each one of her four children (I was the youngest) secretly knew that she/he was her favorite. I admired the humorous, robust Bella Siegel and believed all that she told me.

Sophie Grossman was a blonde, curly haired schoolmate in my second grade class. We had fun together and exchanged secrets. Once, Sophie confided that she knew where babies came from and I was proud to admit that my mother explained that to me recently. We were shocked to learn that our stories did not match and began to argue about it. There was only one logical solution; when school was out, we would walk to my home and ask my all-knowing mother.

After the usual hot cocoa and cookie, I asked my mother to give us the correct information so that I could accept Sophie's apology.

"Mama", I inquired, "You told me that a stork brings the new babies and Sophie says that a seed is planted in the mother to make the baby grow. Who's right, me or Sophie?"

As my mother calmly stirred her cup of Postum, she replied, "You are both right. Sometimes the stork brings the baby, but when he is too tired to carry it, he plants a seed in the mother and it grows into a new baby."

When I was a little older, I worried about the stork's very pointy beak and hoped that he wouldn't be too tired when it was time for him to bring me my baby. Nevertheless, Sophie and I remained friends but she never challenged me again.

My lovely mama had no belly button !! She used to physically help my father in their used furniture store. When there was no other man around to assist my father in moving a heavy piece of household goods, my mother would help him lift very hefty items, including a piano. She began to be troubled with pains in her abdomen and finally submitted to a hernia operation. In those days, the doctors made a huge vertical incision down the center of her belly. When the repairs were performed, the belly button disappeared.

Sophie, and several of my other pals did not believe me when I boasted that my mother didn't have, or need a belly button. Once again, we marched to my house after school so that I could prove what a cool mom I had. We didn't get the cocoa and cookie this time, but my good natured parent allowed my buddies to check her out. No, she did not lift her housedress to reveal her missing orifice, but she allowed the curious kids to gently run their fingers down the center of her celebrity tummy. They really admired the fact That there was no indentation and could hardly wait to run home and tell their families and

neighbors. I was a real hero that day!

The reason I titled my mother a diplomat is because she liked to make everyone feel special. This in turn, most likely made her feel special too. Whenever as an adult, I visited her home, I was impressed that she always had a framed photograph of me displayed in the living room. My sister Bunny mentioned one day that our mother was so thoughtful to always have her photograph exhibited whenever she dropped in. My curiosity got the better of me, and during a subsequent visit, I discreetly picked up my framed picture and noticed a small bulge on the back of the frame. You guessed it ! There were three other photos of my siblings neatly stacked and ready for a quick change. Somehow, when several of us were there at the same time, the suspect photo was nowhere to be found.

Mama Bella was an excellent cook and everything she made was very tasty. For several reasons, economical and emotional, she liked for us to finish everything in the plate. She would stand by and watch as we devoured our dinner and would plop another spoonful onto our platters as soon as we were almost done. I was shocked to hear myself paraphrase her words when my children were growing up. No it wasn't "Millions of children all over the world are starving, so be sure to eat all your food." I never got the logic in that anyway. But I repeated her words, "All the good vitamins are at the bottom so be sure to finish up everything." Luckily, we were all active and had fine metabolisms and did not turn into blimps.

Although we were raised in a Jewish home, Christmas was a joyous time of year and we always had fun during that season. We hung stockings on the kitchen chairs, not really expecting anything, but sort of hoping. My mom would fill her daughters stockings with nuts, candies, barrettes, tangerines etc. My brother, who was the apple of her eye, got onions, garlic, banana peels and peanut shells.

Before school ended for the winter holidays, my mother took up a collection from the other mothers of my classmates and we proudly presented our teacher with a beautifully wrapped Christmas gift. With glistening eyes and a flushed face, our teacher, Miss Mabel Jennings, nervously opened her holiday present. She was really overcome with gratitude when she held up and admired a warm pair of woolies. For those of you who are not acquainted with that item, woolies are cozy, knitted underwear, which reach the tops of the knees. My mother told the others that she wished she had also brought the poor thing a jar of chicken soup.

I suppose I have inherited this diplomacy or fabricator gene, because I so love to make people happy, and I confess that I sometimes exaggerate or embellish a wee bit. But that's what art is, right? And beauty and kindness are so good for the soul. Besides, a little chicken soup and embellishment would nourish the bodies and spirits of all those perpetually starving children. *** finis ***